

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/9: Common Buddhist foundation

COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE

suffering (duḥkha) -> origin (tṛṣṇā/avidyā) -> cessation (nirvāṇa) -> eightfold path

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three marks: anitya | suffering (duḥkha) | anātman

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dependent origination supplies the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad):

neither eternal substance nor causeless annihilation

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later schools disagree about what exists and how it is known,

not about the need to end ignorance and craving.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/9: Practical and doctrinal Middle Path

MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMA PRAṬIPADĀ, PĀLI: MAJJHIMA PAṬIPADĀ)

practical extremes: sensual indulgence X self-mortification

positive route -> Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga)

wisdom + ethical discipline + meditative discipline

doctrinal extremes: eternalism X annihilationism

dependent origination preserves conditioned continuity without a permanent self

Four Noble Truths -> cause -> cessation -> path -> liberation

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/9: Twelve-linked dependent origination

ignorance (avidyā) -> saṃskāra -> viṣṭāna -> nāma-rūpa -> ṣaḍyatana -> sparśa

-> vedanā -> tṛṣṇā -> upādāna -> bhava -> jāti -> jarā-maraṇa

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IGNORANCE conditions formations; craving and grasping renew becoming

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“When this is, that comes to be; with cessation of this, that ceases”

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reverse order: end ignorance (avidyā)/tṛṣṇā -> break appropriation -> end rebirth-duḥkha.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/9: Momentariness and no-self

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratityasamutpāda) -> conditioned things arise and perish -> MOMENTARINESS

(kṣaṇikavāda)

causal efficacy belongs to the moment; no unchanged bearer is required

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PERSON ANALYSIS -> five aggregates (skandhas)

rūpa | vedanā | saṃjñā | saṃskāra | vijñāna

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none is permanent, independent or “mine” -> NO PERMANENT SELF (nairātmyavāda)

continuity = causal series, like flame-to-flame; identity is neither strict sameness

nor total unrelatedness.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/9: Action and moral consequence (karma), memory and cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa)

NO ENDURING SELF (ātman), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY

intention at t1 -> conditions stream -> fruit at t2

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memory = later cognition causally conditioned by earlier experience

rebirth = one psycho-physical series conditions another, without soul-transmigration

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objection: if agent perishes, another receives result

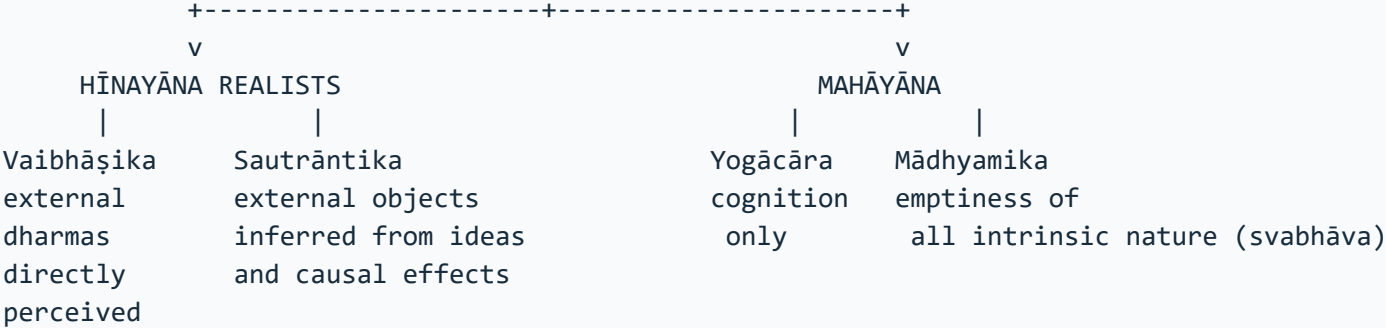
reply: successor is neither identical nor wholly different; causal appropriation connects

cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not

destruction of a substance-self.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/9: Abhidharma school fork

BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE



SCHOOL LABELS MARK EPISTEMIC/ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS, NOT FOUR PATHS TO MIX.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/9: Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika

ISSUE	VAIBHĀṢIKA	SAUTRĀNTIKA
external object	real dharmas	real momentary causes
access	direct perception	inferred from mental image
past/future	sarvāstivāda: dharmas exist	only present causal moment stressed
cognition	grasps object	represents object

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SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT: object-moment is gone when awareness occurs;
therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.
PRESSURE: representative realism must explain correspondence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/9: Yogācāra and Mādhyamika

YOGĀCĀRA / CONSCIOUSNESS-ONLY DOCTRINE (vijñānavāda)

MĀDHYAMIKĀ / EMPTINESS (śūnyatā)

subject-object duality is constructed	all things lack intrinsic nature (svabhāva)
vijñapti-mātra: representation-only	dependent arising = emptiness
store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) stores	bīja tendencies two truths: saṃvṛti / paramārtha
three natures: parikalpita,	tetralemma rejects is / is-not /
paratantra, pariniṣpanna	both / neither as ultimate capture

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CONVERGENCE: dissolve reification; DIFFERENCE: Yogācāra privileges purified cognition,
while Mādhyamika empties even consciousness and emptiness itself.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/9: Critique and PYQ answer spine

OBJECTIONS: flux cannot explain continuity | anāton weakens agency | emptiness (śūnyatā) is nihilism

REPLIES: causal series | dependent responsibility | emptiness denies self-nature, not function
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ANSWER RAIL

common core -> twelve links -> momentariness -> five-skandha no-self

-> action and moral consequence (karma)/memory reply -> four-school fork -> exact school comparison

-> objection/reply -> qualified verdict
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CLOSE: Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process; its schools progressively debate whether external dharmas, cognition, or any intrinsic nature can be retained.